

Photoshopped Nano

An obvious Photoshop job, showing a car driver in a TATA Nano going to his owner's house, was sold as fact by Malsekhar

Incubating lives

Banny Bannerjee's \$25 incubator could transform lives in the rural world and reduce infant mortality rates

innovations from the poor and let them spread into viable businesses to help the base of the pyramid." He said.

Entertainment

The first session of TED India was broadcasted live on the internet. Hans Rosling and Devdutt Patnaik both gave spirited talks that had the crowd on their feet. Both seemed destined to be TED classics. This feel-good trip almost reached burnout levels when Usha Uthup came on stage. Half the crowd was in tears when she did a medley of an Arabic song, followed by an Israeli number – what with her joyful gait, big puppy dog eyes, magnified by plus power glasses.

It was the perfect demonstration of the built-in empathy circuits in all of us, which

TED conference. There was plenty of comedy as well. In his talk about ancient water conservation techniques, Anupam Mishra humbly requested the audience to turn off their internal spell and grammar checks for the duration of his talk. He spoke in vernacular, but made the crowd laugh throughout, with superb wit and timing.

Design

Design for extreme affordability - Gandhian Design was the mantra that resonated on Day 1 – "More for less, for more." said Raj Malsekhar, in an inspiring talk where he spoke openly about his poverty, and how an educational scholarship given to him by the Tata group was the ticket out of his humble origins.

which invests in know-how and does seed funding in web startups like Ycombinator.

A talk by Guy Spiers stressed on the importance of checklists as a personal organisation tool. He had lost his wallet in New York City cabs thrice, despite his self-professed genius and academic credentials. His life improvement suggestion? Use checklists - they have drastically reduced hospital infection rates by drilling hand-washing rituals into doctors; there was a checklist which outlined what to do in the event of an airplane crash. (It's a long bullet point checklist that should be followed to the T) and more how using one yourself could help you prevent losing your belongings. He has never lost another wallet again.

Other design ideas came from the TED goodie bag; sadly, there were no iPods or iPhones – it was more Gandhian in that respect. Horst Rechelbacher, an ecopreneur and founder of Intelligent Nutrients, gave away a nutritious lip balm made out of herbal food ingredients. The package proudly displays its eco-friendly logo credentials – no animal testing, manufactured with 100 per cent Certified Renewable Energy, Certified Organic. "Everything we put in and on our bodies

You'll find a detailed article on SixthSense in the May 2009 issue of Digit. Pranav Mistry is also among Young Indian Innovators featured in our October special.

neuroscientist V S Ramachandran had spoken about a day before. Mirror neurons in our brains are fired when we see someone perform an action – dance, play music, or slip on a banana peel. "It's only because of a constant feedback from touch receptors that the human brain is able to differentiate between self and others", he said.

Like a Bollywood movie, song and dance were essential ingredients of the

From the Jaipur foot to the Tata Nano, India has always been an incubator for low-cost solutions. Anil Gupta's talk on rural innovations showcased a \$1 non-stick pan made out of clay, a pedal-driven bicycle-mounted washing-machine, and a mobile grain grinder created by a villager to grind meagre quantities of cereals for the poor.

Banny Bannerjee, a design professor from Stanford showcased a low-cost infant baby warmer that costs 1 per cent of what incubators in the hospital do. This \$25 baby incubator does not require electricity, and could save millions of lives in India and the rest of the developing world.

Murray Freeman, a new-age Thoreau, shared his architectural solution for low-cost housing in squatter cities. He had constructed a three floored 3,000 square feet dwelling in Bangalore out of pallet racks used in warehouses for Rs. 6 lakhs. According to him, pallet racks are cheap, durable, stackable, and can be assembled or disassembled in a couple of days, leaving a minimal imprint on surroundings. He has also conceived the idea and is developing the courseware for a One MP3 Player Per Child program, and runs a company in Bangalore called Upstart,

must be nutritious and safe" says a quote by Horst on the package. The lip-balm costs \$10, probably ten times more than petroleum jelly versions, but has a great pitch: it makes kissing more nutritious!

There was plenty of India shining at TED India; the speakers were full of choice anecdotes that are par for the course for email forwards on Independence Day. All this pride and congratulation begs the question - is TED coming back? TED India's first event at Mysore was a celebration of India, but now that we are done with the 10Is and the introductions, we need more insight, less inspiration next year. We're Indians, and full of it, anyways. **d**



Noted Director and Writer Shekhar Kapur tore his notes before stepping on the stage at TED

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For those of you who want to see what happened at the TED India conference, watch out for our DVD in January, which will contain a lot of videos from TED Mysore.